> India's forces on the ground, Major General Niranjan Prasad, referred to Tawang as '4 Division's base for life and death'. Tawang was not only the rear base of lndian forces for occupying Bum-la pass and Dongmen-la [Milaktong-la/Bum-la] regions towards North West but also supported lndian forces in the Kejielang region [Nam Ka Chu], which also played the role of a protective screen for the right flank of lndian forces extending up to the 'McMahon Line'. The Indians had administered Tawang for more than a decade. Various types of military infrastructure were almost perfected and they had built a small military airport with a parking apron for helicopters. Tawang had become command centre and supply base for Indian forces that intruded into the Menyu [Kameng] area. However, after the lndian forces at Kejilang and Long bu were annihilated and Bum-la pass was captured by Tibet frontier guards, Indian forces at Tawang were panic-stricken like birds rattled by the mere twang of a bow string.

The Chinese had had the first laugh, as the Indians had so far played the game just as they would have wished them to. Even according to Chinese records, at no stage had there been any action that pitted more than an Indian infantry company against at least four to five times the number of Chinese troops. The Chinese officially admit to 2,419 casualties (722 dead and 1,697 wounded). The figure is quite stunning, given the situation in which each Indian position was asked to fight.

From all accounts, Bogey Sen's presence in Tawang between 22 and 23 October only added to the confusion. Before landing at Tawang, the army commander had flown towards Zimithang to get an idea of the terrain which he was not familiar with at all. Once in Tawang, as we have seen, Sen did nothing to bolster the confidence of the garrison. The meeting with Prasad later in the evening focused on two issues: the Nam Ka Chu rout of 7 Brigade and the immediate withdrawal from Tawang. Bogey Sen opposing a withdrawal only amounted to theatrics, for had he wished, as the army commander, he had the authority to overrule Prasad.

Both officers at the time were unaware that Army HQ, now represented by Monty Palit, was pushing for the same decision. There was a critical difference though—Prasad was planning on falling back on Bomdila with Se-la only playing the part of a delaying obstacle. Palit, on the other hand, based on the one incomplete reconnaissance made almost two years ago, had made up his mind to dig in at Se-la. Thapar having gone along with his DMO, who now had the tacit approval of Nehru, was relegated to the role of a spectator. The Thorat Plan, even though it hadn't been implemented, at least had had some discussions around it and plans had been drawn up. Just as Tawang was abandoned on a whim, Se-la was seemingly chosen arbitrarily by Monty Palit who played the 'cleared by the cabinet' card to ride roughshod over any opposition.